there. Specifically, a place where you are new and there is no base of your organisation, then you have to socialise with people, you have to hit the ground zero time and again, spend hours and hours with the local people, eat what they eat, learn and speak their language, take part in their festivals, be part of their life, only then you will be able to make space in their hearts. We tried to understand their problems and then share them with our people and later found right solution. The training I got from RSS helped me a lot to build organisation there. I worked in Tripura along the same lines as I worked in Meghalaya. I was able to convince 60 new karyakartas to work as Vistaraks.'[131]

In tandem with this local mobilisation, the RSS sent 250 workers in 2016 to Tripura. The number of shakhas in the state doubled from eighty in 2015 to 250 by the time of the election in 2018. It was the 'RSS's boots on the ground that eventually helped breach the Left citadel of Tripura'.[132]

RANI GAIDINLIU AND RESISTANCE TO CHRISTIAN MISSIONARIES: CORE RSS BELIEFS IN THE NORTHEAST

RSS expansion in the Northeast has been driven by three core beliefs: that the region has been part of Greater Bharat since ancient times, that the British wrongly drove a wedge in this ancient cosmology of networks by characterising the region's tribal groups, with their animist beliefs, as separate from Hindus and the idea of Hinduism, and that the growth of Christian missionary work and the rise in conversions in the Northeast are a threat to Indian security stability. Prafulla Ketkar, the editor of *Organiser*, summed up the cultural core of these beliefs in a signed editorial in early 2018. 'Right from Mahabharata period we find references to the sacred places and personalities from the region in our discourse. These brave people did not allow Moghuls to cross Brahmaputra and therefore, remained protected from the Muslim invasions. Taking benefit of this the British, again finding the region difficult to govern, kept it underdeveloped and allowed missionaries to carry on their activities openly. Unfortunately, in the post-independence period instead of rekindling the ancient linkages, we also bought the British narrative and were caught in the tyranny of distance. It was physical as well as